

AFFILIATE / REFERRAL ROADMAP

WaveBase

*How the revenue actually works,
honestly explained.*

For Lode De Waegenare & Michiel De Cooman

Prepared by Claude · May 2026 · v=1



01 — THE RULE THAT COMES FIRST

Content does not depend on revenue.

Before anything else: the wedge of WaveBase is that we write the truth about a spot or stay, based on real reviews. The minute that depends on who pays us, the product is dead — it becomes BookSurfCamps with extra steps. So the governing rule, in stone:

“We write about every place we can verify with reviews — regardless of whether we can monetise it. The affiliate layer sits on top of the editorial, never inside it.”

Practical implication: the 4 Greek stays whose own websites aren't on Booking.com (Akti Villas, Surf Beach Apartments, Flamingo Apartments, Villa Amalia) are listed and reviewed exactly as fully as the ones where we earn a commission. Same goes for any future stays where monetisation isn't possible. Coverage is the moat.

02 — THREE WAYS REVENUE CAN FLOW IN

The three referral routes.

Route 1 — Booking.com Affiliate Partner Network

Booking.com pays a cut to sites that send them bookings. Sign up is free at booking.com/affiliate-program. You get an **aid** (affiliate ID, just a number). Any Booking.com URL with **&aid=YOUR_NUMBER** appended tracks the click. If the visitor books within 30 days, you get paid.

Commission: ~25-40% of Booking's own commission, which is 15-20% of the booking. Net to you: roughly **4-8% of the booking value**. Payouts monthly, threshold around €100. Lowest friction; works at scale; the obvious Phase 1.

Route 2 — Direct deals with the accommodation

You contact the owner: "We're sending you guests via WaveBase. Can we get a tracking link or coupon?" Commission is higher (typically 10-20%), no platform middleman, and the owner knows where the booking came from. Works best for stays with their own booking site.

Slower: each deal is a 1-on-1 negotiation. Worth it for the SOLID-bron entries we already review well — they should be eager to send us guests once they see our recommendation.

Route 3 — Activity affiliates

GetYourGuide, Viator and similar marketplaces have affiliate programs for surf lessons, Paradise Valley tours, hammam bookings, etc. Commission ~5-8%. Adds a revenue layer on top of accommodation. Not urgent for Phase 1, but a natural Phase 3 expansion.

03 — CURRENT STATE

Where each stay currently links to.

The Book Now / Visit Website button on each stay page points to one of two places — Booking.com (where affiliate is immediately possible) or the property's own site (where affiliate requires direct outreach). The current breakdown:

Stay	Country	Booking link goes to	Phase 1 affiliate?
Sunset Surfhouse	Morocco	Booking.com (fallback)	✓ yes
Chillout Surf Hostel	Morocco	Booking.com (fallback)	✓ yes
Solid Surf House	Morocco	Booking.com (fallback)	✓ yes
The Surf Hostel	Morocco	Booking.com (fallback)	✓ yes
Amayour Surf	Morocco	Booking.com (fallback)	✓ yes
Dar Imim Surf House	Morocco	Booking.com (fallback)	✓ yes
Kouremenos Beach Apts.	Greece	Booking.com (verified)	✓ yes
Surf Beach Apartments	Greece	surfbeachapts.gr	outreach needed
Akti Villas	Greece	akti-villas.gr	outreach needed
Flamingo Apartments	Greece	flamingo-apartments-...gr	outreach needed
Villa Amalia	Greece	villa-amalia.com	outreach needed

→ **7 of 11 stays** can be Phase-1 activated by just adding the Booking.com aid parameter. The other 4 are direct-booking-only and require outreach for affiliate.

PHASE 1 · THIS MONTH (10 MIN OF YOUR TIME, 5 MIN OF CODE)

Activate Booking.com affiliate.

Steps

- **Lode** signs up at booking.com/affiliate-program — free, takes ~10 minutes. Provides website URL, accepts the terms. Approval is usually instant.
- Lode passes the **aid number** to Claude.
- Claude updates `bookingHref()` in `app.js` to auto-append **&aid=AID** to any Booking.com URL. ~5 minutes of code.
- Claude adds a one-line footer disclosure: "Some 'Book now' links earn WaveBase a small commission at no extra cost to you — that's how the site stays free for surfers."
- Push. All 7 currently-Booking-linked stays are immediately monetised.

Realistic Phase 1 revenue

Expect **€20–100/month** for the first 3–6 months. Math:

- Average surf stay booking: ~€500-800/week
- Booking affiliate commission ~5% of booking value → €25-40 per converted booking
- To clear €1,000/month, you need ~30 bookings/month through WaveBase → ~5,000-10,000 visits/month with 1-2% booking conversion

This won't fund the project. It's lights-on money + proof the model works. The real margin is downstream (Phase 4).

PHASE 1.5 · THIS MONTH (SAME WEEK AS AFFILIATE)

Plausible — the feedback loop.

Affiliate revenue without analytics is flying blind. We need to know: which entries get views, how long people stay, where traffic comes from, and — most importantly — how often someone actually clicks a Book Now button (and on which stay). Without that signal, Phase 2 outreach is a cold pitch instead of a "we sent you 12 visitors last month" data-driven pitch.

Why Plausible specifically

- **Privacy-first, GDPR-clean by default.** No cookies, no IP storage, no consent banner needed. Matches the honest-wedge — being upfront about tracking is part of being honest.
- **Custom event tracking** is first-class. One line of JS per Book Now button = per-stay conversion counts in the dashboard. Cloudflare's free analytics doesn't surface this.
- **Outbound link tracking** built-in: every external click (Booking.com, own-site bookings) is tracked automatically.

- Cost €9/month, 30-day free trial. Tiny in absolute terms; pays back the moment we use it to inform a Phase-2 outreach pitch.

What we'll see in the dashboard

- Top pages with average time on page → tells us which entries actually *hold* attention vs which get bounced.
- Top sources → confirms whether WhatsApp shares, Google, or direct visits are working.
- Custom events panel: "Book Now: Akti Villas — 12 clicks", "Visit Website: Gone Surfing — 5", broken down per entry.
- Goals + conversion rates: % of visitors who reach a Book Now click. The single number that tells us the model is or isn't working.

Setup

- Lode creates a Plausible account (plausible.io). Adds wavebase.lode-b162.workers.dev as a site.
- Passes the snippet to Claude. ~5 min to paste in the <head> of all pages + wire one event per Book Now button + push.
- Lode + Michiel both log in to plausible.io to view the dashboard. Team members can be added.

Alternative: Cloudflare Web Analytics — free, but blind to the Book Now metric

Cloudflare's built-in analytics is free and zero-effort (it's already in the dashboard where Lode logs in for hosting). Good for pageview + source tracking. But it does not natively surface custom button-click events — so you can see *how many people visited the Akti Villas page*, but not *how many clicked Book Now*. For Phase 1 "is the affiliate model working" question, that's the metric that matters.

Practical recommendation: turn on Cloudflare Web Analytics now (free, 3 min). Add Plausible the same week as the affiliate aid lands. They run in parallel without conflict.

PHASE 2 · MONTHS 2-4 (CONDITIONAL ON FIRST TRAFFIC)

Direct outreach to own-site stays.

Once we have early traffic (even 200-500 visits/month), reach out to the 4 Greek stays whose own websites we link to, and to any Morocco stays with direct booking. The pitch:

"We're WaveBase — a small honest surf guide. We've reviewed your place based on recent guest reviews and we already recommend it on our site. We're sending interested surfers your way. Can we get a tracking link or coupon so we both know when a booking comes from us?"

Commission target: 10-15% of the booking value (much higher than Booking's 4-8%). **Bonus:** aligns interests — the stay wants visibility, we want bookings, both want surfers to have an honest pre-arrival picture.

Order to approach (highest probability of acceptance):

- Akti Villas (we already drive friction-free direct bookings — they get the value most clearly)
- Villa Amalia (well-reviewed, hospitality-focused — likely receptive)
- Surf Beach Apartments (windsurfer-targeted, niche traffic = high relevance)
- Flamingo Apartments (multi-language team, EU-savvy)

PHASE 3 · MONTHS 4-6

Activity affiliates.

Add a layer of activity revenue on top of accommodation. Each spot detail page can carry an activity widget: "Book a surf lesson here" → GetYourGuide. Same flow as Booking — add an affiliate parameter, get paid when someone books.

Candidates

- **GetYourGuide** — broadest catalogue (surf lessons, Paradise Valley, hammams, Atlantic-coast day trips, Crete archaeological tours). Easiest to integrate.
- **Viator** (Tripadvisor's activity arm) — overlaps GetYourGuide but sometimes different listings.
- Specific surf centers' own affiliate (Gone Surfing, Freak Surf) — same direct-outreach model as Phase 2 but for centers instead of stays.

Commission: ~5-8% of activity value. Smaller per-transaction than stays (a lesson is €30-60), but high volume potential — every visitor to a stay page is a candidate to also book lessons.

PHASE 4 · YEAR 2+ (THE REAL MARGIN)

B2B data and insights.

This is the long-term play and the moat. As WaveBase accumulates:

- Structured, honest analyses of hundreds of surf spots/stays across countries
- Aggregate signal of what surfers actually search for, click on, save, compare
- A taxonomy of "situations" — beginner-July, advanced-anti-crowd, wind-foiler-Crete — none of which Booking.com / TripAdvisor surface

Buyers: surf brands (Quiksilver, GoPro, Patagonia surf line, Rip Curl) want to know where their next customers are travelling and what they're prioritising. Tourism boards (Morocco, Portugal, Greece-Crete) want segmentation data on surf tourism. None of them want data on individual surfers — they want aggregate, anonymised, structured insight on the segment.

This is sellable in a way affiliate isn't, and it scales without corrupting the wedge. The earlier we structure our content as data (not just pages), the better positioned we are when Phase 4 lands. Most of what Claude has been doing — typed fields per entry, structured layers, bron-strength labels, JSON-LD — already prepares for this.

LEGAL — THE LAYER THAT MAKES PHASE 4 POSSIBLE

GDPR: what we can sell, what we can't.

Once we hand any data to a third party (surf brand, travel agency, tourism board), the General Data Protection Regulation kicks in. LDW and Michiel are based in Belgium → full GDPR jurisdiction, plus the Belgian Gegevensbeschermingsautoriteit (GBA) as supervisor. Penalties for serious breaches: up to 4% of global turnover or €20M. So getting this right before any data sale is non-optional.

What we CAN sell freely

- **Structured supply-side data** — spots/stays/centers with their fields (coords, sports, levels, brands, season patterns, ratings we distilled). This is business/factual data, not personal data. GDPR doesn't apply.
- **Editorial methodology + analyses** — our distilled reviews, the 4-year-window rule, the source-strength labels, the two-layer analysis approach. This is WaveBase IP.
- **Aggregate demand signal** — "X% of our users searched for Portugal in October", "the wing-foil segment grew Y% this season", "average level of travellers to Crete is intermediate". As long as no individual can be re-identified from the aggregate.

What we CANNOT sell without explicit consent

- Individual user profiles linked to a person (level + board type + email + home country = personal data, even without name).
- Behavioural records linked to individuals (what they saved, compared, planned).
- Email addresses for any marketing purpose.

Selling any of the above requires **specific, informed, freely-given consent for that exact purpose** — not a general "I agree to terms". And it's withdrawable at any time, which means the buyer's contract has to handle erasure requests too.

Architecture that keeps Phase 4 clean

- **Two-tier database:** business data (supply-side + editorial) is physically separated from user data. Different tables, different access controls, ideally different services.
- **Aggregation happens server-side.** Individual records never leave WaveBase. The buyer receives summaries, not rows.
- **k-anonymity threshold:** any aggregate published externally requires ≥ 20 individuals in the underlying segment. Smaller segments aren't released — they're identifiable.
- **Audit trail:** every aggregation that leaves the database is logged with timestamp, buyer, and segment definition. If GBA ever asks, we can show exactly what was shared.

Compliance layer — required before any data sale

- **Privacy Policy** (GDPR Art. 13) — what data, why, how long retained, who else sees it. Plain-language, surfer-readable, not boilerplate.
- **Terms of Service** — the contract with users.
- **Cookie / tracking banner** — explicit consent for non-essential cookies (analytics, marketing pixels). Essential cookies (the localStorage that powers Save / Compare / Trips) are exempt.
- **Granular consent flow at sign-up:** (a) basic site functionality, (b) personalisation, (c) anonymous aggregate research — opt-in default, (d) marketing email — opt-in default OFF.
- **DPA** (Data Processing Agreement) with every B2B buyer — contractually limits how they use the data, prohibits re-identification attempts, requires deletion on request.
- **User-rights endpoints:** access, correction, deletion (Art. 15-17). Self-service inside the account page where possible.

Current QnD status — where the GDPR clock starts

Right now WaveBase stores everything in [localStorage](#) — the user's own browser. WaveBase is not yet a *data controller* in the GDPR sense, because no personal data has crossed onto our servers. **The moment a backend goes live**, all of the above must be in place. The tipping point isn't traffic or revenue — it's the first backend deploy.

Practical phase plan:

- **Pre-backend (now):** Lode + Michiel read GDPR Art. 6 (legal bases) and Art. 13 (info to data subjects). One evening's work.
- **Backend launch checklist:** privacy policy, ToS, consent flow, DPA template, user-rights endpoints. Estimated 1-2 weeks of focused work; can be done with a Belgian privacy lawyer for ~€2-4k or with template-based tools (Iubenda, Cookiebot) for ~€500/year.
- **Pre-first-data-sale:** confirm aggregation pipeline meets the k-anonymity threshold; draft a Phase-4-specific DPA template for buyers; optionally contact GBA's startup support track for a free advisory consultation.

What this means for what we build now

Two implications for current architecture decisions:

- **Keep the user-data minimal until the backend is real.** The current profile fields (birth year, level, gear, etc.) are fine to keep in localStorage. Don't expand the schema speculatively — every new field is a future consent burden.
- **Design the data layer with separation in mind from day one.** Every entry in `data.js` today is structured business data — that's the sellable layer. When we add user-side data later, it must live in a parallel structure, never merged.

“GDPR isn't friction — it's the moat. The buyers who can comply trust the suppliers who comply. The B2B contract is shorter when the seller is clearly clean.”

REALITY CHECK

What kind of money is actually on the table?

Stage	Traffic / month	Conversion	Avg comm	Bookings	Est. revenue / month
Soft launch	100-300	1%	€30	1-3	€30-100
Word of mouth	500-1,500	1.5%	€30	7-22	€200-650
First SEO traction	3,000-8,000	1.5%	€35	45-120	€1,500-4,000
Established niche	15,000-40,000	2%	€40	300-800	€12k-32k
+ Direct deals + Activities	same	+50%-effective comm	—	—	1.5× of above

Rough estimates. The point is the curve: affiliate revenue grows sub-linearly with content, linearly with traffic. The data/B2B layer is where the curve breaks open.

GUARDRAILS

Three rules that keep the wedge intact.

1. Coverage is non-negotiable

Every spot/stay we can verify with reviews stays on the site, regardless of whether it earns us anything. Drop coverage and you become BookSurfCamps.

2. The review pipeline doesn't change because of money

We don't bury weak spots on stays that earn commission. We don't soften minpunten. If anything, we lean harder on honest minpunten precisely because we earn from those entries — it's the trust premium that makes the affiliate convert in the first place.

3. Disclosure is permanent

A footer line on every page: "Some links earn WaveBase a small commission at no extra cost to you. That's how this stays free for surfers." Plus EU-required (LDW is in Belgium), and it actively reinforces the honest-friend wedge — being upfront about money is part of being honest.

NEXT STEP

What we need from Lode this week.

Action 1 — Sign up for the Booking.com Affiliate Partner Network: booking.com/affiliate-program. Use `wavebase.lode-b162.workers.dev` as the site URL. Approval usually within 24 hours.

Action 2 — Once approved, paste the aid number to Claude. Claude wires `bookingHref()` + adds the footer disclosure. That's Phase 1 done.

Action 3 (same week) — Set up the measurement layer. Sign up for a Plausible account at plausible.io (30-day free trial, €9/month after). Pass the script snippet to Claude — 5 minutes of wiring and the dashboard goes live. Optionally enable Cloudflare Web Analytics in parallel (free, already in your hosting dashboard).

Action 4 — Decide whether to start outreach to the 4 own-site Greek stays now (Phase 2) or wait for the first 200-500 visitors. Recommendation: wait. Reach out with a real "we sent you N visitors last month" story, not a cold pitch.

Action 5 (pre-backend) — Lode + Michiel read GDPR Art. 6 (legal bases) and Art. 13 (info to data subjects) once together. One evening; demystifies the whole thing before any backend code gets written. The Belgian Gegevensbeschermingsautoriteit also runs a free startup support track worth contacting before the first real data sale.

ONE-LINE SUMMARY

Affiliate is lights-on revenue and proof-of-model. The wedge is the asset. The data layer is the exit.